

Needing to BELONG

The Self & Social Identities

WHO READ THE SYLLABUS?

DIVERSITY & INCLUSION: *Diversity is having people who are different, inclusion is making sure that everyone feels like they belong.* My goal is to ensure that everyone—regardless of their identities—feels like they belong. Some of the topics we cover may be harder or easier for some of you to discuss than others. Thus, it is essential that our classroom be a place where everyone feels comfortable expressing their thoughts without fear of being judged. I expect all of my students to be respectful of the widely varied experiences and backgrounds presented in the classroom and you can expect the same level of respect from me. Disrespect or discrimination on any basis, including but not limited to ethnicity, race, sex, sexual orientation, ability, income, class, or religion, will simply not be tolerated. Email me your favorite meme by the end of the first week of class for a bonus point. If someone (even me!) says something you find offensive, try to find a way to express how you feel in a constructive manner in class or set up a time with me. Please let me or your TA know if you have any issues or questions about these policies.

Think About a Time You Really Belonged



Family



Sports



Friends



Choir



Gaming



Clubs



Culture



Community

What’s your Need to Belong?

- **1 (strongly disagree) to 5 (strongly agree)**

- 1. If other people don't seem to accept me, I don't let it bother me.
- 2. I try hard not to do things that will make other people avoid or reject me.
- 3. I seldom worry about whether other people care about me.
- 4. I need to feel that there are people I can turn to in times of need.
- 5. I want other people to accept me.
- 6. I do not like being alone.
- 7. Being apart from my friends for long periods of time does not bother me.
- 8. I have a strong need to belong.
- 9. It bothers me a great deal when I am not included in other people's plans.
- 10. My feelings are easily hurt when I feel that others do not accept me.

What’s your Need to Belong? (reverse score)

- **1 (strongly disagree) to 5 (strongly agree)**

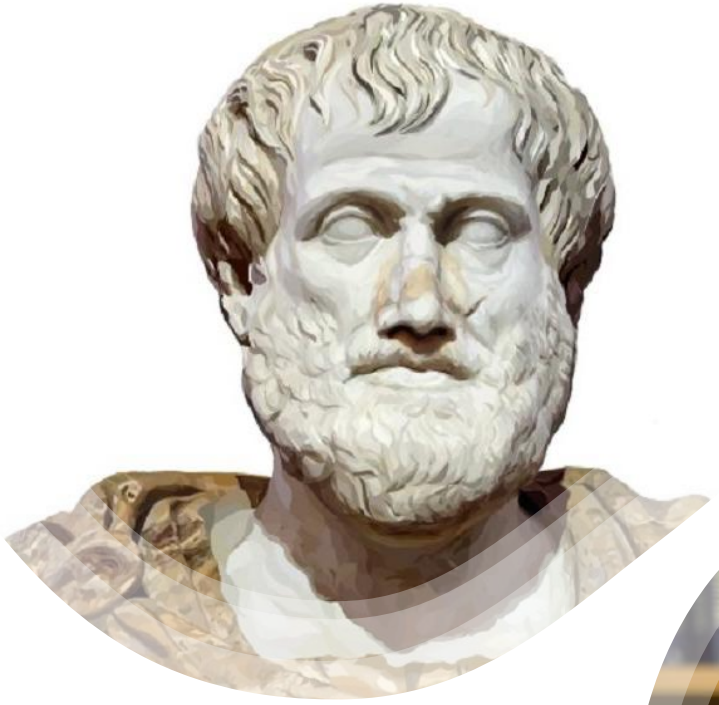
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What's your need to belong?

- How often do you think about fitting in?
- When are you happiest and when does being a part of a group matter the most?



Needing to Belong







- Psychologist and Philosopher Aristotle wrote:
  - *“Without friends, no one would choose to live…”*
- Human beings have an “urge to community” or to form relationships
- Roy Baumeister and Mark Leary created the Need to Belong Scale

Defining a Need to Belong

- **<u>Need to Belong:</u>**
  - a need to form and maintain at least a minimum quantity of relationships

  Would interactions with strangers or with people one dislikes or hates satisfy the need?

  Only certain emotions can fulfill attachment but needing to belong could be fulfilled in other ways

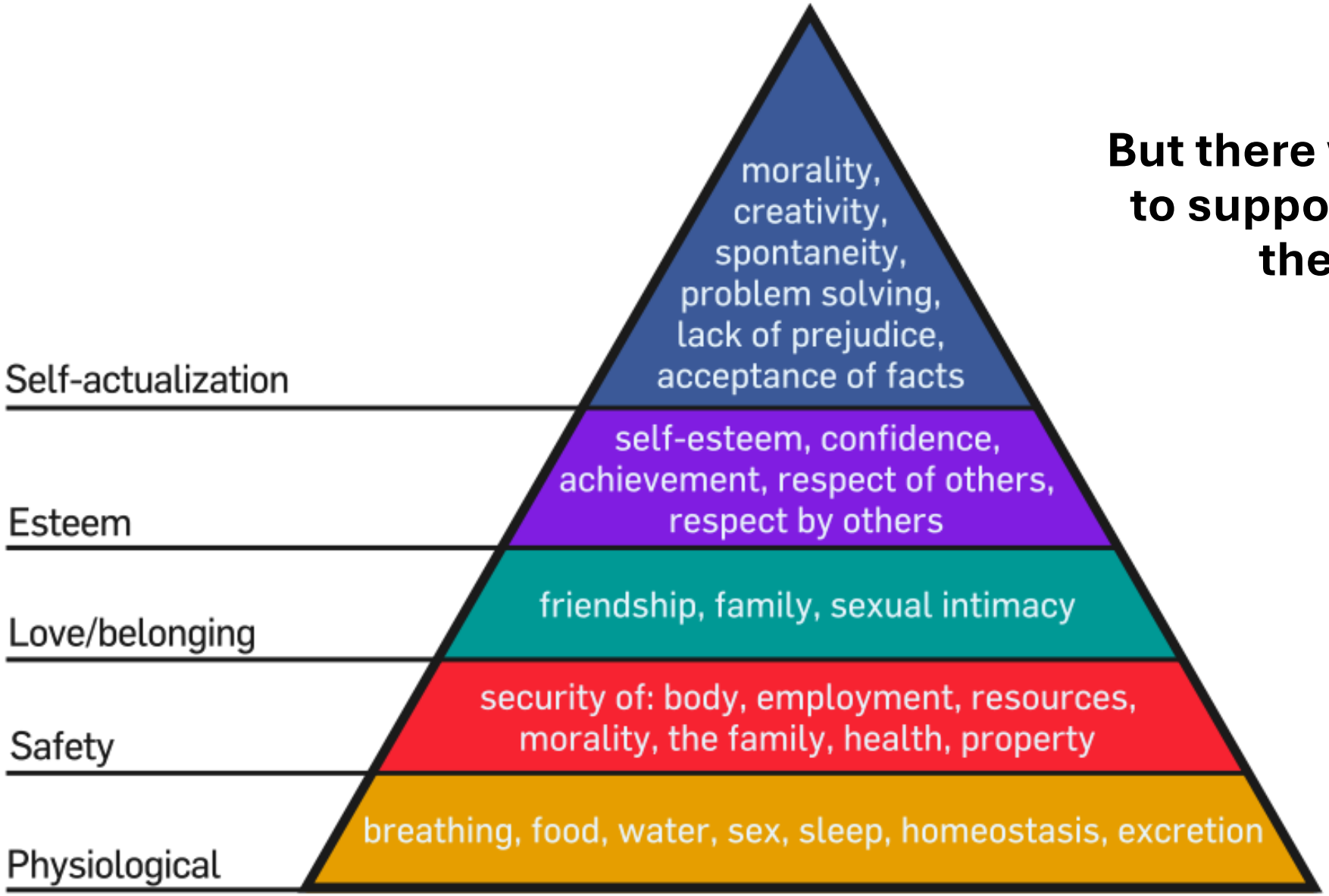




What Does Belonging Actually Mean?

- **<u>Two Main Components:</u>**
  - People need frequent, personal, and positive interactions with others
  - People need to perceive that there is an interpersonal bond marked by stability, affective concern, and continuation into the future

Maslow's Hierarchy of Needs (1968)



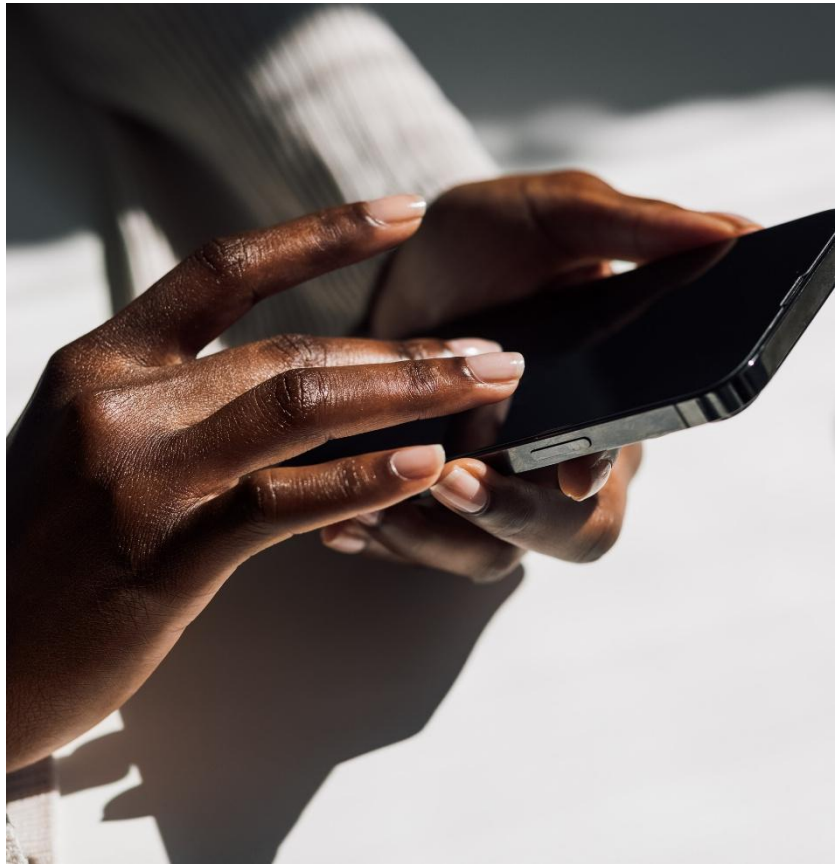
But there was no data to support to this at the time

Why Do We Check Our Phones?

Looking for information…

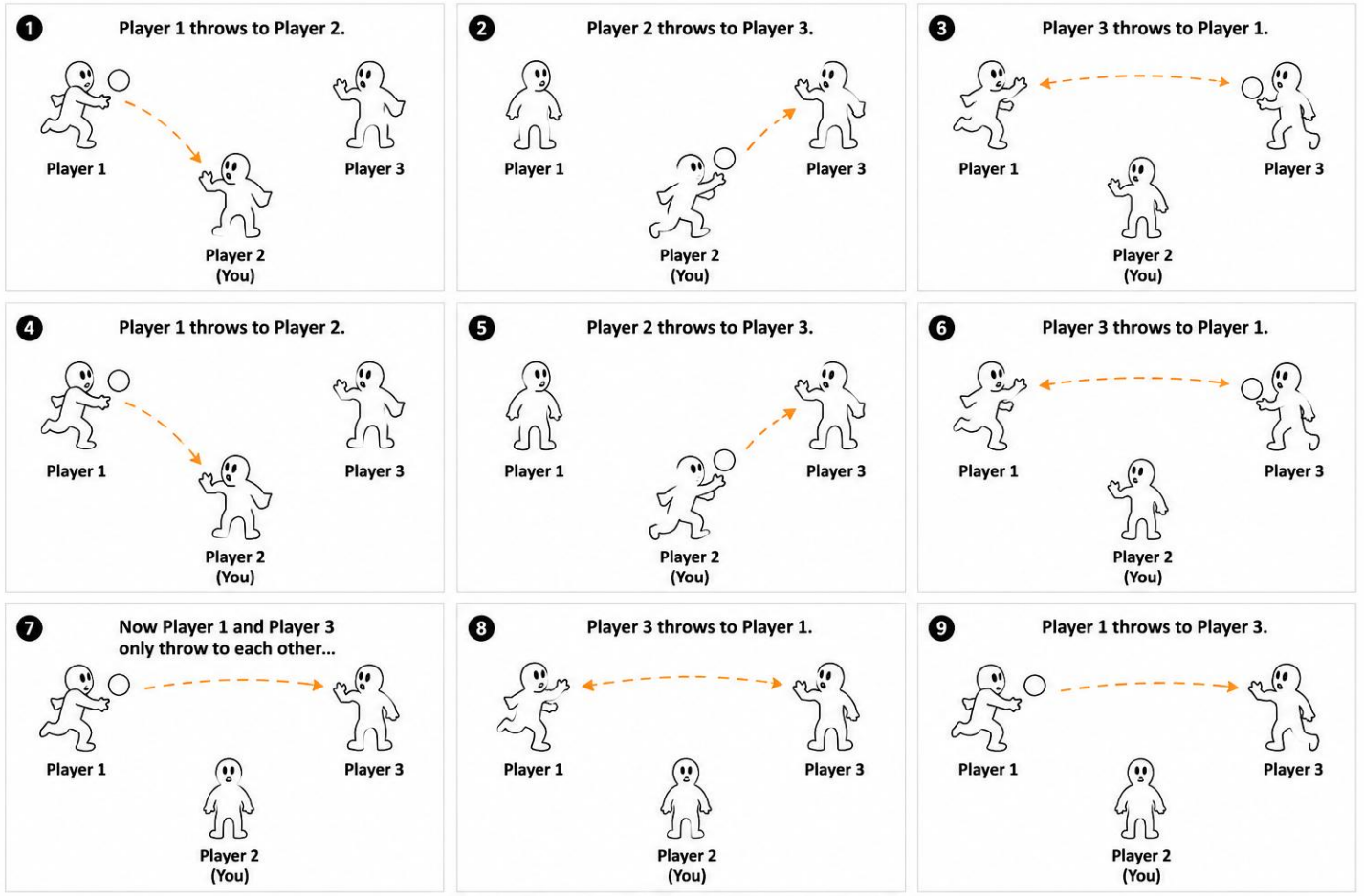
…or looking for connection?

Social behavior vs. social motivation



What Happens When We Don't Belong?

- Social exclusion (**ostracism**)
- Even brief exclusion affects: mood, self-esteem, behavior



Eventually, Player 2 (you) is left out and does not receive the ball.

Kip Williams' Cyberball

Ostracism and Social Pain



What do you think of these quotes?

- **“No person is an island”**

- **“People need a few close relationships, and forming additional bonds beyond those few has less and less impact. Having two as opposed to no close relationships may make a world of difference to the person's health and happiness; having eight as opposed to six may have very little consequence.”**

- **“When a social bond is broken, people appear to recover best if they form a new one.”**



Belonging Signals Activity

With Your Group Discuss:

- Three subtle cues that could communicate “you belong here.”
- Three cues that could communicate exclusion or uncertainty.
- How the experience might differ for someone high versus low in need to belong.
- One small, realistic change that would make the setting more inclusive.

Belonging Signals Activity

- What was your context, and what is your best advice to change belonging?

- *Is belonging mainly something individuals seek, or something groups and institutions create?*



Discussion Questions

Baumeister and Leary argue that belonging requires frequent, positive interactions with people who care about us. Does that mean belonging is about the number of relationships we have, or the quality and security of a few relationships?



Discussion Questions

When does the desire to belong become unhealthy? What are some signs that a relationship or group is meeting a belonging need versus exploiting the fear of rejection?



Discussion Questions

Can fully online relationships provide belonging? What features would make an online relationship feel real and secure rather than superficial? And links to social media?

Next Class...

- Intergroup Conflict & Groups
- Paper 1 Discussion

